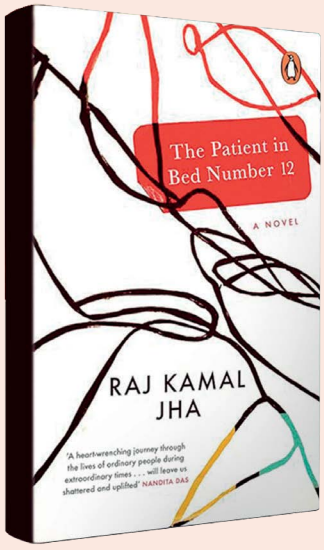
THE PATIENT IN BED NUMBER 12
By Raj Kamal Jha
PENGUIN
₹599; 272 pages



but more viscerally, novelists do the same essential work of careful listening, of attempting such empathy as to enter the consciousness of others. In *The Patient in Bed Number 12*, the eponymous patient, having betrayed his daughter, comes belatedly to understand the necessity of listening—"Often, I bring my ear close to their heads so that I can listen to their thoughts, the buzz and crackle inside, their neural fires burning. Sometimes, if I am lucky, I find a broken heart and squeeze myself in through its cracks. To flow with their blood. In the narrows of their vessels, unnoticed and unfelt."

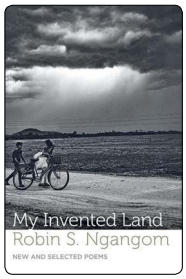
That word 'lucky' is inadvertently revealing though too, revealing of the predatory nature, alongside the empathy, of the writer's work. As much as Jha is an essential writer, as harsh as is the glare off the mirror he turns on us, something about his aestheticisation of Indian horror makes me squirm. It shouldn't be necessary to remind readers that all reviews are stamped with an invisible but indelible "IMHO", but I'm going to anyway. IMHO, Jha's self-consciously beautiful prose, which too frequently edges into sentimentality and schlock, has the unfortunate effect of making the violence more surreal and fantastic than shocking.

Raj Kamal Jha's book tells stories of people who do terrible things, or to whom terrible things are done, or both

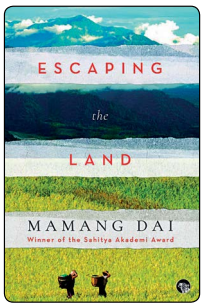
But shocking is what the violence—pulled straight from the headlines—is: shocking, ugly, and profoundly shaming. Hope is the thing with feathers, Emily Dickinson wrote. And by the end of *The Patient in Bed Number 12*, Jha has his characters don feathers, gives them the wings they need to soar clear of this hellscape we have made for ourselves. But hope is not the enduring message of this novel—it is despair at the sight of the maggots writhing under the rock Jha has lifted on Indian society. And the maggots are us. ■

Shougat Dasgupta

MY INVENTED LAND
New and Selected Poems
By Robin S. Ngangom
SPEAKING TIGER
₹399; 184 pages



Robin S. Ngangom has published several books of poetry; *My Invented Land*, his latest, puts some of that older work alongside new poems, and is his best. There are few poets around anymore who write poetry with a moral charge instead of an agenda–Jayanta Mahapatra used to, Nissim Ezekiel was a pioneer. Ngangom grew up in Manipur, has lived for decades in Shillong, and could be considered a poet of the Northeast experience. But this is filtered through a lifetime of reading world poetry that makes his voice educated and polished but also personal and pained: "Land of my childhood/I can no more pretend to love" and "We are but shadows of the great spirits/who come from myth, and/are but shadows themselves".



ESCAPING THE LAND
By Mamang Dai
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 312 pages

Mamang Dai is a favourite–her *Black Hill* was unforgettable–and her latest, *Escaping the Land*, is the story of Arunachal told through the life of a man who has zinged through the mythic and the modern eras. Politics rules, yet the memories of another way of living are still honoured, even if only in private. This listening in to people talking is the stuff of the novel–their familiarity with shamans who could bring down rain, their despair over Arunachal's troubles, their thinking of the "NEFA days". The sympathetic visiting writer, Verrier Elwin on, has given us one view of the region. Dai's fiction comes out of a modern sense of loss and how the native might put that into words.